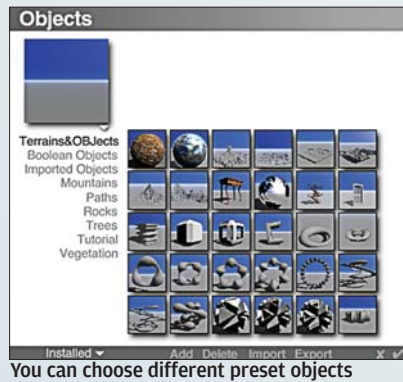


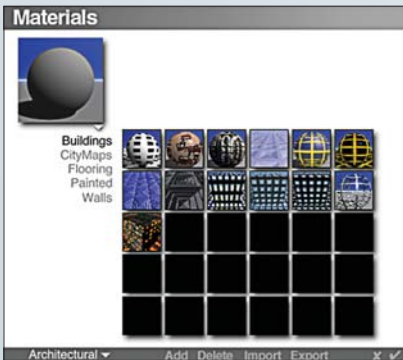
the sun to night mode; clicking on the small rectangle at the bottom left of the sphere will let you choose the colour of the sun.

Quick Menus For Presets



You can choose different preset objects

Each of the toolbars we've talked about has quick menus that can be accessed by clicking on the small triangle at the right (of Create, Edit, as well as Sky & Fog). You can access preset objects in here, or you can save your custom creations for later use. This makes sets of theme scenes easier to create. For example, say you've created a decent model of a car. Instead of saving the scene and repositioning it for every subsequent picture with the car, you could just save the object group under the user section of the quick create window, and place it in your scene in a jiffy.



Choose a preset material for the scene

Next is the much-used quick menu for the Edit toolbar, which again lets you choose from a selection of preset textures and materials. Again, you can also save user-created presets here.

Finally, the quick menu for the Sky & Fog toolbar lets you create and save custom skies. You may not feel the need to make your own skies, but we recommend that you do, because all the preset skies leave the scene shrouded in black—since the clouds block out the sun! If you create it from scratch, you can let the sun shine through.



You can choose presets of environments here

The Animation Tool

Bryce comes with a complete animation tool. The animation is controlled by means of a small toolbar at the bottom right of the window. Select File > Animation Setup, and specify the duration of the animation as well as the frames per second. To animate a scene, first create the first one (using the composite image you've created) with the slider at the 00.00 position. Now make the animation toolbar completely visible by clicking on the Time / Selection Palette Toggle (the small sphere at the extreme bottom right of the window). Then click the little Plus beside the icon that looks like a key. Next move the slider forward to a desired time in the animation (the measurement is in seconds). Then change the location, shape, and texture of objects in the first scene.

When you press Play, the objects will get animated. The results are similar to a 3D morph. (You can also curve the objects' paths.) That's how you make animations in shape and position, but if you want to animate the material of the object, there is the material editor.



The Materials Lab: Lots of options to play with!

Select Objects > Edit Material to open the Materials Lab. Here, you can change aspects of the object's texture such as ambience, specular, bumpiness, transparency, reflection, refraction, and more, and wrap textures around them. You will notice the familiar animation control at the bottom of the window, and it can be used in the same way as before. You

can change the texture according to the time slider and click the Plus icon beside the key icon to add a key event. When you render this animation, the texture will change scene by scene according to what you've done in the animation.

Work better with Bryce Texture Presets

Since textures are the basic building blocks of materials, it would have been great to have a preset menu for textures, like you have for materials. Well, it is there, but hidden. To access it, instead of simply clicking to get the texture list pop-up, hold down the [Shift] key while clicking on the texture name or the button beneath it. Now you can view the graphical texture presets dialog, which not only allows you easily select textures, but also lets you import and export textures.

Precise Placement Of The Sun and/or Moon

If you would like to place the sun and/or the moon at a precise location in the picture, you can do it this way: first select the Sky&Fog Palette, hold down [Ctrl] + [Alt], and double-click on the sky sphere. This is to switch to the sun/moon placement mode. Hold down [Ctrl] + [Alt] and click into the scene to place the sun at the cursor position. To place the moon at the cursor position, hold down [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Shift].

Negative Lights (Virtual Black Holes)

In Bryce, light can have a negative value in the Light Editor. So while the upper limit for this is 999 (very bright light), the lower limit is -999. In the latter case, the source will suck the surroundings, creating an eerie, unreal effect. As you might have guessed, the shadows casted in this case will be bright. Give it a try—amazement guaranteed!

It's Good Fun

Bryce 5.5 is a great 3D illustration and rendering program, we think, and is equally useful for the beginner as well as the expert graphics artist. While it does not offer advanced CAD-style 3D creation or figurative animation capabilities, it is an effective tool for achieving attractive 3D scenery and well-lit environments.

Go ahead, create a stunning landscape, put it up as your wallpaper, but don't submit it to wallpaper sites. It's yours! ■

jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com